

3. **Expensive sports.** I'll be forever grateful that neither of my kids was interested in sports like hockey, ice skating, or baseball. Not only am I cheap, but I hate the hours: getting up at the crack of dawn to schlep them to the arena or skating rink . . . no, thanks. If your kid's been bitten by the hockey bug, *Forbes* estimates you'll spend \$1,500 to \$3,000 in gear alone, and if the team travels, you can tack another \$1,000 to \$3,000 onto the budget. Does your kid love figure skating? Private coaching and rink time cost between \$200 and \$300 a month. You'll easily spend over \$200 on new skates, and competitions cost hundreds of dollars—not counting hotels and other travel costs. Even baseball bats can run \$300 to \$400 for the high-end stuff. And of course, your kids will outgrow their equipment and uniforms quickly; that's what kids do. Yes, there are equipment swaps, and a community rec center or the YMCA might offer cheaper options than private teams and clubs. But unless your child is really passionate about these sports or shows signs of being the next Wayne Gretzky or Michelle Kwan, thereby ensuring a return on your investment, sign him or her up for soccer or basketball instead.
4. **Special diet plans.** You've seen the ads. For as little as \$25, you can lose twenty-five pounds. But what those ads fail to mention is that their program costs a little bit of money to join, but a fortune to lose the weight. That's because you're buying *their* food and *their* supplements, which is how those companies make *their* fortune. It's one of the biggest rackets on the planet. People either never lose the weight or rarely keep it off, yet they all too readily sign up for the next new thing to promise that this time it'll work. Depending on how many of the services and products you buy, a popular weight-loss program can cost you between \$5,000 and \$10,000 a year. Instead, consult your family doctor about a personalized diet plan. It's free, safe, and as effective as anything else.